DEBATING TECHNOLOGICAL ISSUES

OVERVIEW

Applying leadership and 21st century skills, team members collaborate to prepare for a debate against a team from another chapter. The teams are instructed to take either the Pro or Con side of a topic from an annual theme.

The theme and topics for this event will be posted on the TSA website under *Themes & Problems*.

ELIGIBILITY

Three (3) teams of two (2) individuals per state may participate.

TIME LIMITS

Refer to Preliminary Round Procedure for time limits.

ATTIRE

TSA competition attire is required for this event.

PROCEDURE

PRE-CONFERENCE

A. Participants review the TSA Honor Statement for Competitive Events found in the General Rules.

B. Participants review the Use of Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) found in the General Rules.

C. Participants review the annual theme and topics posted on the TSA website under *Themes & Problems*.

D. Participants research all topics and should be prepared to debate any of the topics from both Pro and Con views.

E. Reference Material

1. Reference material is defined as the pre-researched, verifiable evidence used to support or refute specific claims during a round.
    a. All reference material must be printed and secured in a 3-ring binder.
    b. Teams are limited to one binder.
    c. Materials should be organized by topic to facilitate rapid retrieval during the debate.

F. Documentation Portfolio (two [2] complete copies required):

1. Documentation materials (comprising "a portfolio") are required and must be secured in a clear front report cover with the following single-sided, 8½" x 11" pages, in this order:
    a. Title page with the event title, the team identification number, the conference city and state, and the year; one (1) page
    b. Table of contents; pages as needed
    c. Reference list. The reference list is a formal, curated bibliography of all source material used to prepare for the debate. It serves as a summary document provided to the judge to verify that the team has conducted legitimate, academically rigorous research.
        i. Reference list must be printed on single 8½" x 11" paper; both sides may be used.
        ii. References for all three (3) topics must be consolidated onto one (1) sheet of paper.
        iii. Document must be typed in 10-point font or greater.
        iv. MLA format is mandatory. Listing URLs alone does not constitute an appropriate citation.
    d. Resources and AI Reflection (see 2027 & 2028 Forms Appendix); maximum of four (4) pages.

CHECK-IN

A. One participant from each team must attend a pre-debate meeting at a time and place stated in the conference program to:

1. Show the event coordinator the two (2) copies of the documentation portfolio. Failure to show two (2) copies of the documentation portfolio disqualifies the team from participation.
2. Sign up for a competition start time.
3. Receive general information and directions.

PRELIMINARY ROUND

A. Participants report to the preparation room before their scheduled competition start time with their reference lists.

B. In the preparation room, teams will be informed of their topic for the debate and be randomly assigned a Pro or Con designation. Teams will have one (1) minute to prepare for the debate.

C. Upon entering the competition room, each team will provide the judges a copy of their documentation portfolio (which will not be returned).

D. Two (2) teams will debate the topic for the preliminary round.

E. Judges independently judge each debate.

F. A list of twelve (12) semifinalists (in random order) is posted.

SEMIFINAL ROUND

A. Semifinalists report at the time and placed stated in the conference program to sign up for a semifinal time.

B. Semifinalist debates follow the same procedure as in the preliminary round.

C. The top ten (10) finalists will be announced during the conference awards ceremony.

REGULATIONS AND REQUIREMENTS

Students will work to develop their leadership and 21st century skills in the process of preparing for and participating in this TSA competitive event. The development and application of those skills must be evident in their submission, demonstration, and/or communication pertaining to the entry.

PRELIMINARY ROUND

Debate Procedures

A. Participants should report to the preparation room fifteen (15) minutes before their scheduled competition start time with their reference list and any other materials.

B. When ready, teams will be escorted into the preparation room, where the topic for the preliminary round will be announced. One (1) team will draw a card to determine their Pro/Con designation. The other team will have the opposite Pro/Con designation. Teams will then have five (5) minutes to prepare.

C. At the end of the preparation time, teams will be escorted to the debate room.

D. Order of debate format:

1. Pro Speaker (maximum of 2 minutes)
2. Con Speaker (maximum of 2 minutes)
3. Team Conference Period (1 minute)
4. Pro Cross Examination of Con (maximum of 2 minutes)
5. Con Cross Examination of Pro (maximum of 2 minutes)
6. Team Conference Period (1 minute)
7. Pro Rebuttal (maximum of 2 minutes)
8. Con Rebuttal (maximum of 2 minutes)

E. The escort introduces the Pro team by identification number and the team is instructed to sit to the left side of the podium (from audience perspective). The Pro team should give a copy of their reference list to the judges. If teams do not have a copy of their reference list then they will not be able to participate in the debate.

F. The escort introduces the Con team by identification number and the team is instructed to sit to the right side of the podium (from audience perspective). The Con team should give a copy of their reference list to the judges. If teams do not have a copy of their reference list then they will not be able to participate in the debate.

G. When the judges and teams are ready, the Pro speaker is instructed to move to the podium and begin.

1. Timing starts when the speaker begins.
2. After one (1) minute and forty-five (45) seconds, the timer holds up a 4" x 6" card that reads “15 seconds.”
3. Penalty points are deducted if a speaker exceeds the allotted time.

H. When the Pro speaker is finished and has been seated, the Con speaker moves to the podium and begins, according to the same procedure as the Pro speaker.

I. When the Con speaker is finished and has been seated, the timer announces a one (1)-minute Team Conference Period where both teams many discuss/ prepare their cross examination.

J. At the conclusion of the one (1) minute Team Conference Period, the timer announces that the conference period is over and the Pro Cross Examination speaker approaches the podium. The Con team, will remain seated.

1. Timing starts when the speaker begins
2. After one (1) minute and forty-five (45) seconds, the timer holds up a 4" x 6" card that reads "15 seconds."
3. If the Con team is in the process of answering a question, the team may finish its answer, provided it does not exceed an additional 15 seconds beyond the allotted two (2) minutes. At this time, the team is cut off by the timer.

K. When the Pro cross examination speaker is seated, the Con cross examination speaker approaches the podium.

1. Timing starts when the speaker begins.
2. After one (1) minute and forty-five (45) seconds, the timer holds up a 4" x 6" card that reads "15 seconds."
3. If the Pro team is in the process of answering a question, the team may finish its answer, provided it does not exceed an additional 15 seconds beyond the allotted two (2) minutes. At this time, the team is cut off by the timer.

L. At the conclusion of the cross examination, the teams are given a one (1) minute Team Conference Period to prepare their rebuttals.

M. Timer announces the end of the Team Conference Period and the Pro rebuttal speaker approaches the podium.

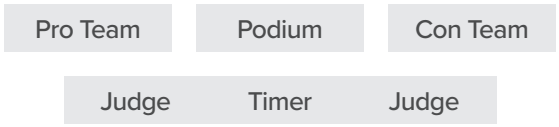
1. Timing starts when the speaker begins.
2. After one (1) minute and forty-five (45) seconds the timer holds up a 4" x 6" card that reads "15 seconds."
3. Penalty points are deducted if a speaker exceeds the allotted time.

N. When the Pro rebuttal speaker is finished and has been seated, the Con rebuttal speaker moves to the podium and begins, according to the same procedure as the Pro rebuttal speaker.

O. When the Con rebuttal speaker is finished and has been seated, the timer announces to both teams that they may leave the debate room.

Debate Details and Notes

A. Room set-up:



B. Participants may not have access to electronic devices of any sort (cell phones, smart watches, laptops, etc.) in the preparation room or debate room.

C. Teams are penalized five (5) points for speaking over the alloted time. Note: There is no penalty for answering questions over the allotted time in the cross examination portion.

D. Pre-written notes may be used. Notes must be hand written (not typed) on 3" x 5" notecards.

E. A three (3)-ring binder of reference materials may be used during the debate. All reference material should be cited on the reference list that was provided to the judges.

F. Participants are permitted to use blank or lined 8.5" x 11" paper or 3" x 5" index cards to take handwritten notes during the debate.

G. No audio-visual materials of any type may be used.

H. Participants are not allowed to view or hear the debates of other teams, aside from the team they are debating.

I. Participants may use their own stopwatches to time themselves. These may only be traditional stopwatches; cell phone stop watches are NOT ALLOWED.

J. No observers or assistants are allowed in the preparation room.

K. For each team both participants must speak at the podium at least one (1) time. Only one (1) speaker is allowed at the podium at any time.

L. Cross examination (questioning) of the opposing team is to remain civil. Any aggressive behavior, belittling of opponents, or shouting results in immediate disqualification of the offending team.

M. If there is an odd number of teams entered in the event, one team debates twice, based on a random drawing for teams that wish to go twice. (Note that the coordinator may not force a team to go twice if it does not wish to do so.)

N. If a team debates twice, it may or may not have the same Pro/Con side of the debate.

1. The team also is required to provide an additional copy of the reference list to the judges.
2. Highest score of the twice-debating team is used as its score.

SEMIFINAL ROUND

A. Semifinalists report at the time and placed stated in the conference program to sign up for a debate time.

B. Participants report to the preparation room at the assigned time.

C. Preliminary round procedures are used for the semifinal round.

D. If observers are allowed in the debate room during the semifinal debates, the following shall be observed:

1. No audio or visual recording devices are allowed.
2. No talking or gesturing is permitted.
3. Observers are not allowed to enter or exit during a debate. Observers should only enter or exit between debates.
4. There is no applause until the debate is completed.
5. Semifinalist teams that have not debated are not allowed to be observers.

Please refer to the conference page of the TSA website or the Spectator Events page of the conference program for additional information.

EVALUATION

A. Debate

B. Documentation portfolio

Note: Scores are reset for the semifinal round and are not added to the preliminary scores.

Refer to the official rating form for more information.

GENERATIVE ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) is permitted for this event. Refer to the Use of Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) for Competitive Events found in the General Rules and Regulations.

STEM INTEGRATION

This event aligns with the STEM (Science, Technology, Engineering, and Mathematics) educational standards.

LEADERSHIP AND 21ST CENTURY SKILLS

This event provides opportunity for students to build and develop leadership and 21st century skills including but not limited to – Communication, Collaboration/Social Skills, Initiative, Problem Solving/Risk Taking, Critical Thinking, Perseverance/Grit, Creativity, Relationship Building/Teamwork, Dependability/Integrity, and Flexibility/Adaptability

CAREERS RELATED TO THIS EVENT

This competition has connections to one (1) or more of the careers below:

- Broadcast media specialist
- Lawyer
- Motivational speaker
- Public relations executive

Participant/Team ID# _____

DEBATING TECHNOLOGICAL ISSUES

2027 & 2028 OFFICIAL RATING FORM

HIGH SCHOOL

Judges: Using minimal (1-4 points), adequate (5-8 points), or exemplary (9-10 points) performance levels as a guideline in the rating form, record the scores earned for the event criteria in the column spaces to the right. The X1 or X2 notation in the criteria column is a multiplier factor for determining the points earned. (Example: an "adequate" score of 7 for an X1 criterion = 7 points; an "adequate" score of 7 for an X2 criterion = 14 points.) A score of zero (0) is acceptable if the minimal performance for any criterion is not met.

Go/No Go Specifications

- Before judging the entry, ensure that the items below are present; indicate presence with a check mark in the box.
- If an item is missing, leave the box next to the item blank and place a check mark in the box labeled ENTRY NOT EVALUATED.
- If a check mark is placed in the ENTRY NOT EVALUATED box, the entry is not to be judged.

☐ Two (2) team members are present
☐ Reference list is present
☐ ENTRY NOT EVALUATED

DEBATE (110 points)				
CRITERIA	Minimal performance	Adequate performance	Exemplary performance	Record scores in the column spaces below.
	1-4 points	5-8 points	9-10 points	
Points of Argument (X1)	Team does not get the attention of the audience, and/or does not outline points clearly.	Team makes an effort to grab the attention of the audience; previewing points are somewhat organized in a logical manner.	Introduction uses an attention getter, clearly states the thesis, and previews main points of the argument; team is cognizant of the audience.	
Organization (X1)	Main idea may not be focused or developed; introduction is undeveloped; transitions may be needed.	Main idea is adequately presented, but the organizational structure may need to be strengthened; ideas are generally developed and flow smoothly.	Main idea is clearly presented, well-developed, and firmly supported.	
Knowledge (X2)	Team does not have a grasp of the information; inaccurate, generalized, or inappropriate supporting material is used; there is an over-dependence on notes.	Team has a partial grasp of the information; supporting material is adequate and the team is at ease.	Team has a clear grasp of information; citations are introduced and attributed accurately; team demonstrates full knowledge, with explanations and elaboration, of the subject area.	
Delivery (X2)	Delivery detracts from the message; eye contact may be very limited; presenter may tend to look at the floor, mumble, speak inaudibly, fidget, or read from notecards; gestures and movements may be jerky or excessive.	Delivery generally seems effective, however, use of volume, eye contact, vocal control, etc., may not be consistent; some hesitancy may be observed; vocal tone, facial expressions, and/or other nonverbal expressions do not detract from the message.	Delivery is extemporaneous, natural, confident, and enhances the message; posture, eye contact, smooth gestures, facial expressions, volume, pace, etc., indicate confidence, a commitment to the information, and a willingness to communicate.	
Cross Examination (X1)	Questions posed to the opposing team show a minimal knowledge of the topic and do not leave much room for discussion; discourse initiated by the team to opponents is often hostile/aggressive and unproductive.	Questions posed to the opposing team show an adequate knowledge of the topic and prompt reasonable discussion; discourse initiated by the team to opponents is sometimes unproductive.	Questions posed to the opposing team show excellent knowledge of the topic and prompt eloquent discussion; discourse initiated by the team to opponents is respectful and its relevance propels the debate forward.	

DEBATE (110 points) – continued				
Question Responses (X1)	Team's responses are minimally sourced and do not fully answer the questions posed.	Team's responses are moderately sourced and mostly answer the questions posed.	Team's responses are fully sourced and completely answer the questiowns posed.	
Rebuttal (X1)	Rebuttal is generic or pre-scripted; team effectively ignores the opponent's case, repeating their own opening points without addressing the specific claims or evidence presented by the other side.	Rebuttal presents logical counter-arguments that address the opponent's specific claims; however, the team tends to focus on minor discrepancies rather than the debate's central conflicts.	Rebuttal decisively dismantles the opponent's core case; team identifies the main conflicts, directly refutes the opponent's evidence, and clearly explains why their impacts outweigh the opposing side's.	
Voice and Language (X1)	Language choices may be limited, peppered with slang or jargon, too complex, or too dull; language is questionable or inappropriate for the audience.	Language used is mostly appropriate, respectful, or inoffensive; word choices are adequate.	Language is familiar to the audience, appropriate for the setting, and free of bias; word choices are vivid and precise.	
Group Member Participation (X1)	Participation is lopsided; one (1) team member dominates the majority of the speaking time (Initial, Cross-Ex, and Rebuttal); other team member is disengaged or silent; leadership and/or 21st century skills are not evident.	Both members participate; team divides speaking roles (Opening, Cross-Ex, Rebuttal) between members so that both voices are heard; both members demonstrate adequate knowledge during their respective sections.	Strategic and balanced partnership; team members share the workload equitably through a clear division of roles that highlights each member's strengths; both members show clear mastery and ownership of the topic during their active times.	
			DEBATE SUBTOTAL (110 points)	

DOCUMENTATION PORTFOLIO (20 points)				Record scores in the column spaces below.
CRITERIA	Minimal performance	Adequate performance	Exemplary performance	
	1-4 points	5-8 points	9-10 points	
Portfolio Components (X1)	Portfolio is unorganized and/or is missing three (3) or more components.	Portfolio has most components and is generally organized per the order of the event guide listing; it has sufficient content.	All components are included in the portfolio; content and organization per the order of the event guide listing are excellent.	
Resources and AI Reflection (X1)	Form is incomplete or vague and does not clearly explain whether or how AI was used, showing little connection to the submission or understanding of effectiveness and ethics.	Form is complete and clearly explains AI use or the lack thereof with connections to the submission or theme/topic (when applicable), addressing effectiveness and ethical considerations with adequate analysis.	Form is complete, concise, and specific, critically evaluating how AI or non-AI tools shaped decisions and outcomes, with strong alignment to the submission or theme/topic (when applicable) and ethical reasoning.	
			DOCUMENTATION PORTFOLIO SUBTOTAL (20 points)	

Rules violations (a deduction of 20% of the total possible points for the above section) must be initialed by the evaluator, coordinator, and manager of the event. Record the deduction in the space to the right. Indicate the rule violated: _____	
Time violation (a deduction of five [5] points total will be incurred for exceeding the debate time limit). Record the deduction in the space to the right.	
To arrive at the TOTAL score, add any subtotals and subtract rules violation points, as necessary. TOTAL (130 points)	

Comments:

I certify these results to be true and accurate to the best of my knowledge.

JUDGE

Printed name: _____ Signature: _____

DEBATING TECHNOLOGICAL ISSUES EVENT COORDINATOR INSTRUCTIONS

PERSONNEL

A. Event coordinator

B. Judges:

1. Preliminary round, two (2) or more
2. Semifinal round, two (2) or more

C. Timekeeper/Announcers

1. One (1) timekeeper/announcer per heat room; timekeepers may serve as judges

D. The escorts for moving teams from preparation room to debate room

1. One (1) per heat room; escorts may not serve as judges

MATERIALS

A. Coordinator's packet, containing:

1. Event guidelines, one (1) copy for the coordinator and for each judge
2. TSA Event Coordinator Report

B. Signs that read "DEBATE in PROGRESS" for all rooms, as needed

C. One (1) stopwatch for each debate room

D. A 4" x 6" card with the message "15 seconds" written on the card, one (1) card for each debate room

E. A 3" x 5" card with "Pro" written on the card and a 3" x 5" card with "Con" written on the card, for each preparation room

F. Podium for each debate room

G. One (1) table and two (2) chairs for the Pro side and one (1) table and two (2) chairs for the Con side for each debate room

H. One (1) table and three (3) chairs for judges and timekeeper/announcer for each debate room; one (1) chair in the back of the room for the escort

I. Chairs for observers during the debate, if applicable

J. Three (3) tables and three (3) chairs in the preparation room for event personnel and participants

RESPONSIBILITIES

AT THE CONFERENCE

A. Attend the mandatory coordinator's meeting at the designated time and location.

B. Report to the CRC room and check the contents of the coordinator's packet.

C. Review the event guidelines and check to see that enough personnel have been scheduled.

D. Inspect the area or room in which the event is to be held for appropriate set-up, including room size, chairs, tables, outlets, etc. Notify the event manager of any potential problems.

E. Develop a heat schedule, taking into consideration the number of preparation and debate rooms, the number of entries, and the time allotted for the event. Twenty (20) minutes should be allowed for each debate.

F. From the list of topics, choose one topic to be used for each round. The topic chosen must apply for all teams.

G. At least one (1) hour before the event is scheduled to begin, meet with judges/assistants to review time limits, procedures, regulations, evaluation, and any other details pertaining to the event. If questions arise that cannot be answered, speak to the event manager before the event begins.

H. Ensure the judges have access to the online judging system.

EVENT CHECK-IN

A. Create the following sign-up sheets:

1. Debate time

B. Pre-debate meeting:

1. Determine the number of teams present.
2. Allow the team representative to sign up for a preliminary round time. Heat rooms will be determined in the preparation room.
3. Provide general information and directions including reminders for teams to bring their reference lists and other materials to the competition.

PRELIMINARY ROUND

A. Begin the event by checking in the participants when they arrive at the preparation room at their scheduled time.

B. When both teams are present in the preparation room, have one (1) team draw a card from the Pro/Con cards. The card will determine which side that team is on, the other team will be the opposite.

C. Record the view (Pro/Con) each team is presenting on the scheduling sheet.

D. Have the escort take the teams to the debate room.

E. The escort announces to the judges the identification number of the Pro team first and then the Con team.

   1. Each team provides a copy of their reference list to the judges and then sits on their designated side of the podium.
   2. Judges need to record each team's identification number on the judge's evaluation sheet.

F. The escort should remain in the debate room until the end of the debate, then escorts each team from the room. This process of escorting teams into and then out of the debate room for competition takes place until all teams have participated.

G. If there is an odd number of teams entered in this event, teams are randomly selected to determine the team that debate twice. If a team debates twice, its highest score is used to determine placement.

H. When the timekeeper/announcer has confirmed that the teams and judges are ready to begin, s/he instructs the Pro speaker to approach the podium and begin.

I. Timing of each debate starts when the speaker begins; however, if there are any unreasonable delays, the speaker is warned by the timer and timing begins.

J. Timing of the Team Conference Period starts once the Con speaker has completed the presentation. The timekeeper informs the teams that they are in the Team Conference Period and also informs the teams when the period is over.

K. Once the Team Conference Period is over, the Pro cross examination speaker approaches the podium and begins, followed by the Con cross examination speaker.

L. Timing of the second Team Conference Period begins once the Con cross examination speaker is seated.

M. Once the second Team Conference Period is over, the Pro rebuttal speaker approaches the podium and begins, followed by the Con rebuttal speaker.

N. When the Con rebuttal speaker is finished, the speaker should return to his/her seat. When the judges are ready, the timekeeper announces to the teams that they are to leave the room and they are escorted out by the escort.

O. While the judges are scoring the teams the escort will begin preparing the next teams in the preparation room.

P. Decisions about rules violations must be discussed and verified with the judges, event coordinator, and CRC manager to determine either:

   1. To deduct twenty percent (20%) of the total possible points in this round or
   2. To disqualify the entry

   The event coordinator, judges, and CRC manager must initial either of these actions on the rating form.

Q. Create a sign-up sheet for the semifinal debates.

SEMIFINAL ROUND

A. Assign semifinalists a debate time.

B. At the time and place stated in the conference program, meet with semifinalists to review scheduling and procedures.

C. Follow the preliminary round procedures, including the selection of pro/con for the semifinal round of debates.

D. All communication related to judges and participants during the debate should be handled by the timekeeper.

E. Discuss rule violations (e.g. 20% deduction, disqualification) and have all relevant parties initial the rating form.

F. If necessary, manage security and the removal of materials from the event area.